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C. God exists. (7,8) (7,8)

We found reason to doubt the idea that, if there is a first cause, then God exists. Do similar doubts apply to premise (8) of Leibniz's argument?

Here we can say things similar to the things we said about quasi-theism when we were discussing the first cause hypothesis.

We can again consider the hypotheses of simple theism and simple atheism, and now consider alongside them the quasi-theistic hypothesis that the universe was created by a being with the unusual property that it is literally impossible for that being not to exist.

It is worth emphasizing one strength of Leibniz's argument as compared to the various versions of the first cause argument. That argument relies on the assumption that there are no infinite causal chains. The kalām argument also relies on the assumption that the universe began to exist at some time.

Leibniz's argument does not rely on either assumption. As he says:

I certainly grant that you can imagine that the world is eternal. However, since you assume only a succession of states, and since no reason for the world can be found in any of them ... it is obvious that the reason must be found elsewhere.

... even if we assume the eternity of the world, we cannot escape the ultimate and extramundane reason for things, God.

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The cosmological argument

We can again consider the hypotheses of simple theism and simple atheism, and now consider alongside them the quasi-theistic hypothesis that the universe was created by a being with the unusual property that it is literally impossible for that being not to exist.

If this strikes you as a strange and unlikely hypothesis, then premise 8 of Leibniz's argument should strike you as a plausible one.

Leibniz’s argument

the
PSR

objections to the PSR

Imagine that the universe is eternal, and that its history includes infinite causal chains with no first cause. So long as the existence of that universe is contingent, the principle of sufficient reason tells us that its existence must have an explanation. And that's enough to get Leibniz's argument off and running.

6. The fact that there are

contingent things is contingent.

contingent things has an

2. Every contingent fact has an

contingent. (3,4)

contingent things is explained by

explained by any contingent thing.

contingent things can't be

1. The fact that there are

3. The fact that there are

4. The fact that there are

some necessary thing. (5)

explanation. (PSR)

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C. God exists. (7,8)

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We can again consider the

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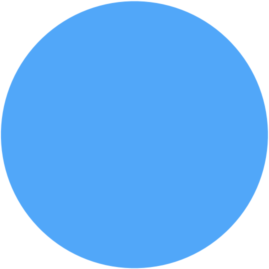
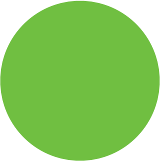


the
PSR



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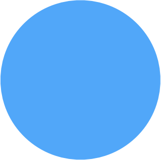


... we cannot find in any of the individual things, or even in the entire collection and series of things, a sufficient reason for why they exist.

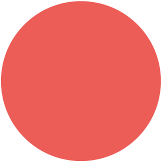
Let us suppose that a book on the elements of geometry has always existed, one copy always made from another. It is obvious that although we can explain a present copy of the book from the previous book from which it was copied, this will never lead us to a complete explanation, no matter how many books back we go, since we can always wonder why there have been such books.

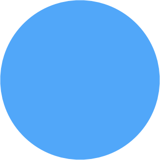
What is true of these books is also true of the different states of the world ... however far back we might go into previous states, we will never find in those states a complete explanation for why there is a world at all, and why it is the way it is.

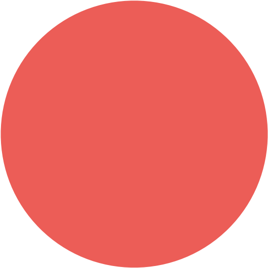
Leibniz's argument

objections
to the
PSR

Last time we considered an objection to Aquinas' assumption that if a first cause exists, then God exists: the objection was that the first cause could simply be some event, like the Big Bang, which is not a plausible candidate to be God.







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The cosmological argument

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